claimed to have been a JW member for 16 years, but grew disillusioned with it six years ago. "They do not celebrate festivals, do not vote, do not join the military or the teaching profession. They won't even sing the national anthem," he stated. His appeals to the sect to mend its ways proved futile, he said. As promised in the video, he surrendered before the police at Kodakara in Thrissur district, two hours from Kochi, the same day.

By this time, the blast had already set off a political storm. BJP leader and Union minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar—who traces his roots to the state—alleged via a vitriolic tweet that Kerala was paying for soft-pedalling on radical Islam. "Dirty shameless appeasement politics by a discredited CM....protesting against Israel, when in Kerala open calls by Terrorist Hamas for Jihad is causing attacks and bomb blasts on innocent Christians," he wrote on X. The next day, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan hinted the Union minister was losing his marbles and was "spewing deadly poison" to further his politics. Later, Chandrasekhar called Pinarayi a "liar". That fit a pattern: a channel war has been playing out of late with TV stations owing allegiance to the Left and the Right sniping away at each other in the state. The slugfest reached a crescendo on October 31 when Kerala Police registered an FIR against Chandrasekhar for promoting 'religious hatred'.

Politics apart, the use of an improvised explosive device (IED) by a seemingly ordinary family man, as well as the knowhow involved in assembling it—allegedly gathered from the internet—is a real cause of worry for a densely populated state of 33.3 million people with all three major religions—Hindus, Muslims and Christians—well represented. Though less stalked by religous violence than the north, the southern state has not been entirely immune to its effects. Nor is it a stranger to IED bombs. On December 6, 1997—the fifth anniversary of the Babri Masjid demolition—an explosion onboard the Chennai-Alappuzha Express had killed four people and injured 55 in Thrissur. It was part of three coordinated train blasts (two in Tamil Nadu) allegedly engineered by the radical Islamic Defence Force. The Kalamassery blast was unique in that a Christian religious gathering was targeted, the suspected perpetrator surrendered to the police and offered several pieces of evidence of the crime.

ASHISH K VINCENT



The JW have been operating in Kerala for over a century after its founder Charles T. Russell, an American pastor, visited the state during British rule. An evangelical sect, they even have a village named after the missionary, Russelpuram, near capital Thiruvananthapuram. Some of the practices that set them apart are following the Hebrew bible, not accepting Jesus as part of the Holy Trinity or celebrating festivals such as Christmas and not donating/receiving blood or organs even for medical emergencies. But they are more famous in India for winning a 1986 case in the Supreme Court, which held that forcing JW members to sing the national anthem violated their fundamental right to religion under Article 25 of the Constitution.

What initially baffled the police was that JW has no history of animosity with other religious groups. Even before the police started preliminary investigation, the media began flashing stories linking the blasts to Islamist terror. "In highly politicised Kerala, everyone plays the role of investigator, reaching conclusions that satisfy their affiliations," says a senior police officer, requesting anonymity. Social media was full of messages saying terror groups were avenging Israel's Gaza bombings, some of them even confusing the JW with the Jewish faith to prove their point. State BJP chief K. Surendran, by contrast, seemed the most tactful on all counts. "They (the JW) are not anti-national. But every detail behind the blasts must be investigated," he told INDIA TODAY.

"The use of IEDs distracted us initially," says M.R. Ajithkumar, additional DGP (law and order) who headed the investigation team. "Our forensic team found traces of petrol at the blast site. We pegged our investigations to two aspects—an insider job or a terror act."

'LONE WOLF' MARTIN?

Velikakathu Martin Dominic, 57, who lived in Thammanam, Kochi, with his wife and daughter, had worked for a few years in Dubai as a construction foreman. He has a son studying in London while the daughter works at the IT Infopark in Kakkanad. Martin had been with the JW for 16 years but left the church about four years ago. No one had any inkling that he was harbouring such anger at the church. On the morning of October 29, Martin left for his flat in Athanni, some 34 km away, where he had assembled the bombs. He arrived at the centre, placed the bombs and recorded the explosions sitting in the back of the hall. Hours later, after putting out a video admitting to the crime, Martin surrendered at the Kodakara police station.